



BUSTED: (clockwise from left) Rizvi being taken in custody; Baig; Babubhai Katara, MP, arrested last year

MODUS OPERANDI

- Travellers pay passport agents up to Rs 20 lakh to procure a US visa and Rs 10-12 lakh for a UK visa.
- Fake documents go to the passport office and the police for verification. Bribes are paid at various stages for clearance.
- For Rs 5,000, police constables verify the fake papers and send them back to passport officials.
- Passport is prepared and passed on to the postal department.
- The postman verifies the applicant's identity and address for Rs 5,000, who is now ready to take the flight of his fancy.

for now they are checking whether all these travellers have returned to India. "More than 40 people had been smuggled to the US and the UK in 2007," says Maria.

Last April, a BJP MP from Gujarat Babubhai Katara was arrested while attempting to take a woman to Canada on his wife's passport. Katara had reportedly struck a Rs 27-lakh deal with Paramjeet Kaur via a travel agent. Police said Katara had made a habit of similarly taking along women to the US and the UK. He forged stamps on the passports to show that the women had returned. In August, a group posing as a film production crew applied for a Schengen visa to travel to Italy. Once granted the visa, they went to Italy, Canada and finally to the US, illegally. Police have arrested five of them and are awaiting the return of one of the accused.

The prospective migrants are generally illiterate labourers who are in search of jobs in the US and the UK but don't have any professional expertise to be eligible for a work visa there. The network is so well-organised that those involved leave few traces behind. "The officers even obliterate records of fake passports," says deputy commissioner of police (crime-detection), Deven Bharti. Once there, the migrants go into hiding and continue to stay on, moving from one town to another.

Bharti says his department is talking to the Ministry of External Affairs to speed up biometric identification of passport applicants. This, when implemented, will help put an end to illegal trafficking. Till date, the authorities are not sure of how far the roots extend. In November, the army was rocked by an organised racket in passports. As the crime branch continues digging, a lot more prominent names may pop up. ■

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